FREE SAMPLE · CHAPTERS 1-3

THE LEASH REACTIVITY RESET

For the dog who barks, lunges and loses control at the sight of another dog on the leash.



A free extract from the 62-page guide

About this sample

This is a free extract from **The Leash Reactivity Reset**, a 62-page force-free training programme for dogs who bark and lunge at other dogs on the leash.

The three chapters here are the ones that change how most owners handle their next walk, before they have trained anything at all: what reactivity actually is, which of the three engines is driving your dog, and the threshold concept that every technique in the full guide depends on.

Nothing in this sample, or in the full guide, will hurt or frighten your dog.

> **A note on safety**
> If your dog has bitten a person or another dog, has redirected onto you, or you feel unsafe on walks, work with a credentialed professional in person rather than from any guide. The full programme explains exactly which credentials to look for.

CHAPTER 1

Your Dog Is Not Being Bad

Let us start by dismantling the thing that is probably making this harder than it needs to be.

When your dog sees another dog and explodes — barking, lunging, spinning, screaming at the end of the leash while you stand there holding a bag of poo and wishing the ground would swallow you — it looks like defiance. It looks like your dog knows the rules and is choosing to break them. It looks, especially when people are watching, like a personal failure.

It is none of those things.

What reactivity actually is

Reactivity is an outsized emotional response to something at a distance the dog cannot cope with.

That is the whole definition. Read it again, because every single technique in this book follows from it.

The behaviour you see — the barking, the lunging — is the **output**. The emotion is the **input**. And emotions are not obedience problems. You cannot correct a dog out of feeling afraid any more than you can punish a person out of a phobia. You can teach them to hide it, which is a different and considerably worse outcome, and we will come back to that in Chapter 5.

What your dog is actually saying

Barking and lunging on leash are almost always **distance-increasing behaviours**. Translated into English, your dog is saying one of two things:

- *"Go away, go away, go away, I cannot handle you being this close."*
- *"Let me get to them, let me get to them, I cannot stand being held back."*

Those two sentences come from completely different emotional places, they look nearly identical from the other end of the leash, and they need slightly different handling. Chapter 2 will help you work out which one you have got.

Notice that neither sentence is *"I am the boss of this walk."* Dominance is not what is happening here. It has not been a credible explanation for this behaviour in the professional world for a long time, and it leads people directly toward methods that make reactive dogs worse.

Why your dog is worse on leash than off

This trips up almost everybody. The same dog who is perfectly civil at daycare turns into a maniac the moment there is a leash involved. That is not inconsistency. It is a completely predictable result of what a leash does:

- **It removes the option to leave.** A worried dog's first choice is always distance. Take that away and the only tool left in the box is "make the scary thing go away by being loud and big."
- **It forces rude greetings.** Dogs naturally approach each other in curves, at an angle, with pauses. Pavements force head-on, straight-line, no-escape approaches — the canine equivalent of someone marching directly at your face without breaking eye contact.
- **It transmits your stress straight down the lead.** When you spot a dog ahead and your stomach drops, you tighten your grip, shorten the leash and hold your breath. Your dog feels every bit of that. You have just told them, through the only physical connection between you, that something bad is about to happen.
- **It creates frustration.** For a dog who genuinely wants to say hello, being physically prevented from doing so, over and over, builds enormous frustration — and frustration, rehearsed for long enough, starts to look exactly like aggression.

Why this matters for everything that follows

If reactivity were disobedience, the fix would be consequences. It is not, so it is not.

Because reactivity is an emotional response, the fix is to **change the emotion**. When your dog genuinely feels differently about seeing another dog, the behaviour changes on its own, without you having to manage it moment to moment. That is what this entire book is doing. Everything else — the distances, the food, the games — is machinery in service of that one goal.

> **The reframe that helps most**
> Your dog is not giving you a hard time. Your dog is having a hard time. On a walk, you are not their boss — you are their bodyguard, their translator, and their escape route. Once you start operating that way, your dog starts trusting you to handle situations, and a dog who trusts their handler to handle it does not need to handle it themselves.

CHAPTER 2

The Three Engines

Leash reactivity is a single behaviour with several possible causes. Working out which engine is driving yours changes what you prioritise.

Engine 1: Fear

This dog wants **distance**. The other dog is genuinely frightening, and barking works — in the dog's experience, barking makes dogs go away every single time, because the other dog always does eventually walk off. The behaviour is being reinforced on every walk whether you like it or not.

What it looks like:

- Weight shifted backwards, or hard forward lunge followed immediately by retreat
- Hackles up along the shoulders or full length of the spine
- Deep, hard, repetitive barking, often with a growl underneath
- Tail high and stiff, or tucked
- Whale eye — the whites of the eyes showing as the dog looks sideways
- Will not take food anywhere near the trigger
- If the other dog actually reaches them, they snap, retreat, or freeze — they do not play

Where it comes from: undersocialisation during the 3-16 week window, a genuinely bad experience (often an off-leash dog charging them), genetics and breed predisposition, pain, or simply a sensitive temperament.

Engine 2: Frustration

This dog wants **contact**, desperately, right now, and cannot get it. Often called a "frustrated greeter." These dogs are frequently the product of a very social puppyhood — lots of dog parks, lots of free play — who learned that every dog they see is a play opportunity. Then one day the leash goes on and the party stops, and the dog loses its mind about it.

What it looks like:

- Weight thrown hard forward, pulling like a sled dog
- Loose, fast, wagging tail — often the whole back end
- High-pitched barking, whining, yelping, screaming
- Bouncing, spinning, jumping on the spot
- Body is loose and wiggly rather than stiff
- Calms down almost instantly if they are actually allowed to greet

- May still take food, just badly and frantically

Where it comes from: a history of on-leash greetings being allowed sometimes, high-arousal play as the default activity, adolescence, and breeds built for high drive and social contact.

> **Why the distinction matters**
> A fearful dog needs distance and safety above everything. Pushing them closer "to show them it is fine" makes them worse. A frustrated dog needs impulse control and a different expectation about what walks are for — and crucially, they need on-leash greetings to stop happening altogether, because every occasional success keeps the behaviour alive on the strongest reinforcement schedule there is.

Engine 3: The Leash And Barrier Effect

This is less a type of dog and more a multiplier that sits on top of the other two. We covered the mechanics in Chapter 1. What matters here is recognising how much of the problem is structural rather than emotional — because that portion is fixable purely through handling, this week, with no training at all.

If your dog is noticeably better in open spaces, on a long line, or when they can move away freely, a large share of your problem is barrier frustration, and improving your handling will produce fast results.

Most dogs are a blend

Very few dogs are purely one engine. A common and frustrating pattern is the dog who started as a frustrated greeter, got told off by enough other dogs (or corrected by their owner at the wrong moment), and gradually converted into a fearful reactor. The body language will often tell you a mixed story.

When in doubt, **treat it as fear**. The fear protocol is safe for a frustrated dog. The frustration protocol, which involves closer proximity and more impulse-control pressure, can genuinely harm a fearful one.

CHAPTER 3

Threshold: The Most Important Idea In This Book

If you take one concept away from this guide, make it this one.

The definition

Your dog's **threshold** is the point — usually expressed as a distance — at which they can still notice a trigger and *think*. Under threshold, they can eat, respond to you, and make choices. Over threshold, the thinking part of the brain is effectively offline and they are running on stress chemistry.

Under threshold, learning is possible. Over threshold, nothing is learned except how to react.

That sentence is the entire strategy.

The arousal ladder

Reactions are not on/off. They escalate through predictable stages, and your job is to learn to spot the early ones:

1. **Notices.** Head turns, ears forward. Perfectly normal and healthy. This is where you want to work.
2. **Alerts.** Body stills slightly, weight shifts, breathing changes or stops. Still fine.
3. **Fixates.** Hard stare, will not break eye contact, stops taking food, may go completely rigid. **This is the point of no return.** After this stage, you are no longer training — you are managing a reaction.
4. **Vocalises.** Whining, low growl, first bark.
5. **Lunges.** Full explosion.

Most owners only start reacting at stage 4, by which point it is far too late. Learning to see stage 2 and act on it is the single biggest handler skill you can develop, and you can start developing it tonight.

Threshold is not a fixed number

Your dog's threshold changes constantly depending on:

- **The trigger itself.** A bouncing adolescent Labrador is not the same trigger as a still, elderly Greyhound. Your dog may be fine at ten metres from one and explode at thirty from the other.

- **Angle and movement.** Head-on approach is far harder than passing at an angle. A trigger moving toward you is harder than one moving away.
- **Environment.** Narrow pavements, alleys and corridors reduce threshold dramatically. Open fields increase it.
- **Surprise.** A dog appearing suddenly around a corner is worth several metres of lost threshold.
- **Your dog's current stress level.** Which brings us to the next chapter.

What this means practically

Your primary job on every single walk, forever, is **distance management**. Not correction. Not commands. Distance.

If that feels like giving up, reframe it: a surgeon does not operate in a bad light and call it discipline. You are creating the conditions in which your dog can succeed, because success is what builds new behaviour. Every reaction you prevent is a rep of the old behaviour that does not happen.

What's In The Full Guide

This sample covered the first three chapters. The complete 62-page programme continues with:

- **Trigger stacking** — why Tuesday was fine and Wednesday was a disaster, and how to plan around it
- **Why corrections backfire**, and what the veterinary behaviour consensus actually says
- **A 10-question diagnostic** to identify which engine is driving your dog
- **Step zero: ruling out pain**, the most commonly missed driver of reactivity
- **A 14-day decompression protocol** to run before any training starts
- **Equipment that sets you up to win**, and the three-tier treat system
- **How to measure your dog's threshold distance** in a single session
- **Five core protocols**: Engage/Disengage, Look At That, Open Bar/Closed Bar, pattern games, and the emergency U-turn
- **A real-world walk strategy** — positioning, escape routes, what to do when a loose dog runs at you, and what to say to "It's okay, he's friendly!"
- **A day-by-day 4-week plan** with a 0-5 scoring scale
- **Troubleshooting for 8 specific situations**, including apartment living and multi-dog households
- **Printable extras**: a 4-week checklist, session log sheets, a pocket walk card, and a body language cheat sheet

Get the full guide

The Leash Reactivity Reset — 62 pages, instant PDF download.

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